Erdbeertorte

German · via Claude

One 9-inch torte (8–10 servings) | Active: ~1 hr | Chill: 2–4 hr | Best eaten same day

BISKUIT (SPONGE BASE)

Ingredients

- 4 large eggs, room temperature
- 120 g (2/3 cup) granulated sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt
- 100 g (¾ cup + 1 tbsp) all-purpose flour
- 30 g (¼ cup) cornstarch
- 1 tsp baking powder

Method

1. Preheat oven to 350°F / 175°C. Grease the bottom only of a 9-inch springform pan and line with parchment. **Do not grease the sides** — the sponge needs to climb.
2. Beat eggs, sugar, vanilla, and salt on high speed for a full 8–10 minutes until pale, tripled in volume, and ribbony. This is the whole game with a Biskuit — the air you whip in is the only leavening that matters. Don't shortcut this step.
3. Sift flour, cornstarch, and baking powder together. Sift again over the egg foam in three additions, folding gently with a spatula each time. Fold just until incorporated — preserve the air.
4. Pour into the pan, smooth the top, and bake 22–25 minutes until golden and springy. Cool 10 minutes in the pan, run a knife around the edge, release, and cool completely on a rack. Can be made a day ahead; some bakers prefer it rested.

STRAWBERRY PREPARATION

Ingredients

- 600–800 g (about 1.5 lb) fresh ripe strawberries, hulled

Method

1. Pick the prettiest, most uniform berries for the top — you want them roughly the same height. Slice a thin flat bottom on each so they stand upright.
2. Use smaller or uglier berries halved or sliced to fill any gaps.
3. Don't sugar the berries — the glaze provides the sweetness.

PASTRY CREAM

Ingredients

- 250 ml (1 cup) whole milk
- 1 tsp vanilla extract, or seeds from ½ vanilla bean
- 2 large egg yolks
- 50 g (¼ cup) granulated sugar
- 20 g (2½ tbsp) cornstarch
- 15 g (1 tbsp) unsalted butter

Method

1. Heat milk and vanilla to a simmer in a small saucepan.
2. In a separate bowl, whisk yolks, sugar, and cornstarch until smooth and pale.

Erdbeertorte — continued

3. Temper the hot milk in slowly, whisking constantly. Return everything to the pot and cook over medium heat, whisking nonstop, until thick and glossy — about 2 minutes of active bubbling.
4. Off heat, whisk in the butter. Press plastic wrap directly onto the surface to prevent a skin and chill until cold.

TORTENGUSS (CLEAR RED FRUIT GLAZE)

The signature finish — glossy, clear, just-set red jelly that locks the berries in. German grocery stores sell packets of Dr. Oetker *Tortenguss rot*; this is the homemade version.

Ingredients

- 250 ml (1 cup) clear red juice (cranberry-raspberry works well; strawberry if you can find it)
- 2 tbsp granulated sugar
- 1½ tbsp cornstarch
- Optional: 1–2 drops red food coloring for a deeper red

Method

1. Whisk everything cold in a small saucepan until smooth.
2. Bring to a boil over medium heat, whisking constantly. Boil 1 minute until thick and clear.
3. Let cool just until warm but still pourable. If it sets too much, gently rewarm.

ASSEMBLY

1. Slice the cooled Biskuit horizontally into two layers. Traditional Erdbeertorte uses only the bottom layer — save the top for trifle or split a second torte. Place the base on a cake plate, ideally ringed with a cake collar or the cleaned springform ring for clean edges.
2. *Optional but traditional:* brush the sponge with a few tablespoons of strawberry syrup, kirsch, or simple syrup to keep it moist.
3. Spread pastry cream evenly over the sponge, about ½-inch thick.
4. Arrange prepared strawberries point-up, standing shoulder to shoulder in concentric circles from the outside in. Pack them tight.
5. Slowly spoon the warm-but-not-hot Tortenguss over the berries, letting it flow down between them and fill the gaps. Work quickly — it sets fast. Don't pour it all in one spot.
6. Refrigerate at least 2 hours, ideally 4, before releasing the ring and serving. Best on the same day.

NOTES AND VARIATIONS

- **Taller version:** use the full sponge, split in two, with pastry cream between and whipped cream + berries + glaze on top. More work, more cake.
- **Kirsch:** a traditional German touch — 1–2 tbsp of kirschwasser in the pastry cream or brushed on the sponge. Authentic and grown-up.
- **Mürbeteig base:** South German and Austrian versions often skip the sponge and use the same shortcrust as the Sun and Moon cookies, pressed into the pan and par-baked. Snappier texture.
- **Other fruits:** the same format works for *Himbeertorte* (raspberries), *Kirschtorte* (pitted cherries, cut-side down), or a mixed *Beerentorte* with strawberries, raspberries, blueberries, and currants.

STORAGE

Same day is best. The glaze holds the berries well for up to 24 hours refrigerated, but the sponge softens from contact with the pastry cream after that. Unglazed components (Biskuit, pastry cream) keep separately — the Biskuit up to 2 days wrapped at room temp, pastry cream up to 3 days refrigerated.

Only as good as its strawberries — save for berry season.